

Chapter 8

Perched on a high stool in a softly illuminated wine bar, Liam wondered if he'd made the wrong decision.

Down a side alley, the otter would never have known such a quaint little place existed. Boxed in locations were something he strictly avoided and he swiftly scooted closer to Timon's back as he followed him down the narrow alleyway with broken paving stones. He tripped, caught himself, and ducked his chin closer to his chest. Close one. A scruffy wolf with threads hanging around the turned up cuffs of his jeans eyed Liam up and down, twice for good measure, a fag dangling from the corner of his mouth. As the otter watched, ash glowed at the end of the cigarette and dropped, grey and forlorn to the gum-splattered flagstones. A wisp of smoke curled towards the cloudy sky and Liam held his breath, only relaxing when they were well clear of the unsavoury character.

Some wolves, he thought with a shudder he tried to conceal, were better avoided. Was Darren one of them? Certain species were still inclined to behave in certain ways. Wolves were often the ones up to no good and the loners were worst of all, scrapping on the edge of society. Some called it prejudice. Liam considered every option, thoughts wandering. What of lions?

"Here we go."

Timon dragged him from his reverie, pausing before a narrow, black door with god paint flaking around the edges. A sign hung overhead: *The Alcove*. They shuffled inside from a suddenly brisk wind and took in their surroundings, Timon with greater familiarity and a light sigh. Perhaps he was happy to be out of the cold too. Liam's eyes adjusted slowly to the softer lighting and he blinked, gaze sweeping over the gleaming bar top, made from dark wood. He could not tell the kind, except that it was of high quality, something that he would like to see in his own home one day. A set of high stools in the same shade stood beside the bar while the remainder of the seating was tucked away in booths and corner tables for privacy.

Timon ordered for him at the bar when Liam confessed he had no knowledge of wine but it was only when the otter slid into the booth with a cradled glass of wine that he realised that the only others in the bar were couples. A meerkat couple spoke quietly with their heads close together, darker stripes painted through tan as if by an artist's brush while a lemur and a fox giggled over their drinks, more than a little tipsy. The otter had not thought that that was what a wine bar was intended for – it was classier than that, surely? Liam studied them. Both female. Perhaps they were high on more than simple liquor...

"Well...this is nice."

Liam leaned back, rudder slapping the leg of the table idly. Timon sipped his wine, completely at ease with his surroundings, shoulders slouched.

"Why did you want to come out to this spot in particular then? You seemed rather..." Liam scratched his head. "Would 'insistent' be the right word?"

Timon had the good grace to look abashed, glancing down into the translucent white wine swirling around the glass with the tilt of his paw. The lion cleared his throat, muzzle

unusually serious in firm, masculine lines. He blinked and Liam wondered if he fell prey to the typical leonine trait of sleeping for the majority of the day. Work must be a bitch.

“It’s somewhere I like to go, usually on my own,” he said, voice a low purr. “I thought you may be the type to enjoy this sort of scene too.”

Looking around, the otter rubbed the back of his neck and returned to his glass. A chandelier hung between the bar and the booth, reflecting crystalline droplets off the concave surface, the stem secure between two fingers and a thumb. Watching light play through the liquid within, Liam relaxed into the murmur of conversation, worries of the outside world melting from his shoulders. It was good to be away, he had to admit.

“It is nice and quiet in here,” the otter said after a pause. “It’s good to be out of the bustle of the city sometimes too.”

Timon laughed, the sound echoing off the walls of the compact space. He was too loud. The bartender frowned, polishing a glass with a white dishcloth.

“Out of the city? We’re on the outskirts! This is nothing like Birmingham or even London, totally different world.”

“Close enough to Birmingham,” Liam countered. “Not that I don’t like the city but we’re pretty much one here in Solihull. Bit more run down than Birmingham as a whole though, I suppose. Wouldn’t want to be closer to Birmingham if I could help it.”

Timon crossed his arms and grinned, one eyebrow raised.

“Oh yeah? Then how would you fare in London? It’s a damn side different to Solihull, I’ll tell you that!”

“I’ve never been,” Liam confessed. “Lived further West before, never came round to it. Not sure how I’d do with the crowds and that train system.” He chuckled. “Too much hot and bother for me really. I need space to, you know, actually breathe.”

“How could you have not been to London?” Timon leaned forward, a paw splayed flat on the table. “It’s amazing! So much to do! Solihull is rural in comparison, you’ve got to know that.”

Liam shifted, struggling to take in the barrage of words as the lion rattled them off, one after the other. He didn’t need to speak. The lion rambled on about the wonders of London and all the things he had done there, all the furs he had met over the years. Liam retreated to his wine and sipped, nodding politely when he thought it appropriate to do so. He finished the entire glass while the lion talked – and could he talk! The otter’s lips turned down in the tiniest of frowns. Did it matter that he’d never been to London? What was the big deal? Would the lion mind that he didn’t like cities? It was a shame the cities were where the ice rinks were. Or else he’d never venture into them at all.

Finally at the conclusion of his sermon, Timon rolled his shoulders back with a languid purr.

“And to think you’ve never used the Underground either!” He lamented. “It’s not the most pleasant of experiences for the whiskers but really – you must go.”

“You speak very...passionately about London,” Liam said. “Have you spent much time there?”

The lion ruffled his mane, brushing back the fluff that had fallen over his wide, blocky forehead. Liam’s fingers twitched with the inexplicable urge to smooth the lion’s hair back into place. He started, surprised by himself. Just where had that come from?

“I’m sorry, I must not have said,” Timon chuckled. “I lived there for a good few years, worked in IT. There’s always a demand for IT work if you keep your skills up to date.”

Liam braced himself for Timon to steamroll on with what could only be an elaborate one-sided discussion of the ins and outs of the IT world. Unexpectedly, the lion instead sat back, shoulders braced against the padded back seat of the booth. Under the tasteful lighting, the dark brown leather gleamed.

“I’m going on a bit, aren’t I?” Timon grimaced. “I do that all the time, bad habit. Oh no, you don’t have to say I don’t do it,” he quickly added, cutting across Liam’s polite protest. “I get carried away. Have a couple of brothers. They liked to take over so I ended up being louder and forwarder than most.”

“I guess that’s okay,” Liam said feebly, toying with the stem of his glass. “At least you recognise it.”

There was no apology and the lack of it left a sour taste on the otter’s tongue. To cover his distaste, for he insisted on remaining polite regardless of how he felt Timon behaved, Liam felt for his wallet. The familiar tickle of nerves, so innocent alone, stirred in his lower abdomen. Timon had bought the first ‘round’ of drinks. It was surely his turn. Yet his wallet groaned.

Timon sipped the last of his wine, hopelessly oblivious to the fidgeting otter. Liam would have laughed aloud if he’d been alone, though there would not have been any humour in it.

“Oh, you’ve finished!” The lion started as if he had only now realised that Liam’s glass had been drained. “Allow me to bring you another.”

Shaking his head, Liam waved him off and placed his wallet on clear view on the table.

“No, no,” he pressed on. “You bought the first one. This is definitely on me. What would you like?”

“Oh, I couldn’t possibly.” Timon smiled and stood. “I invited you here, after all.” He paused, whiskers quivering. “Consider it my treat.”

With a wink, the lion was gone to the bar with a spring in his step that had not been present before. His ropey tail flicked from side to side like the pendulum of a clock, rhythmic and hypnotic. Liam sat frozen, eyes wide and lower jaw slack.

Oh dear.

This wasn't turning out at all like a casual outing between friends.

Gulping, Liam fiddled with his wallet, zipping and unzipping the fabric holder until he half-wrenched it off. Great. He glared at the broken zip, held on by a thread. One more thing to worry about.

How long had it been since he'd been out on a date? Liam wrinkled his nose. Gods. Too long. Not worth thinking about. Was this even a date? Was it not a date? Liam's heart thudded and he willed it to slow. How would he even know either way?

He couldn't very well ask but the lion was already stalking back to the table with two large glasses, full nearly to the brim.

"Funny what being a regular customer will get you," he said as he slid carefully into the booth, not spilling a drop. "Well, that and a little tip on the side. He's a good guy, Nelson is. That's the fox that owns this place," he added by way of explanation.

"So..." The lion eyed him. "What's the deal with you and Darren then? He got you into hockey but you'd never even watched a game before. What's going on there?"

Liam's palms sweated, the fur darkening.

"I... I don't know what you mean," he said, tongue thick in his mouth. "Is that strange?"

"A little. Most have watched games for years or had some interest in it. Or at least that's so in the circles I'm in and was it. It's how it's been."

Liam smiled fixedly, eyes giving away nothing. There was nothing to even give away, not really. Or was there?

"Heh. I guess I'm the exception to your rule then. Darren and I are friends, just friends."

He didn't know why he added the last part but Timon pounced like a...well, like a cat with a mouse. Or otter, as it were.

"Friends, is it?" He probed, less than delicate in his inquisition. "Why are you just friends then?"

He sat back, a grin plastered across his muzzle. Timon shook his finger at the sweating otter, wagging it as if scolding a cheeky kitten. His eyes twinkled, shining with mischief not malice.

"Liam, you are an easy one to read, do you know that?"

The otter's spine stiffened and he pointedly looked away, sipping from his wine. The new glass was sweeter, more of a dessert wine, and sat sourly on his palate. His lips pursed and he flattened a paw on his thigh, fingers digging in lightly.

“What do you mean there?” He said carefully.

“Friends don’t look at friends the way you look at Darren.” Timon smirked. “You can’t keep your eyes off him. Especially in the changing rooms. It’s okay, you know. Jamie’s girlfriend got into hockey through him too. Even plays keeper when we need her. It’s not a bad thing to have happen, to have a boyfriend get you into the sport.”

Liam’s cheeks burned.

“I think you may just be mistaken there. There is nothing going on between us. You must be misreading something.”

His wording was too formal to be truthful and the otter knew it.

“Sure, sure, of course there’s nothing at all going on between a certain otter and a certain wolf.” Timon chuckled, wine going to his head and darkening the insides of his ears. “I’m sure you’re not on each other’s *Bark After Dark* accounts or anything, nope, not at all.”

What on earth? Liam stared blankly at the lion who burst into a full-throated roar of laughter, making other patrons turn their heads in annoyance. The otter held his breath until his lungs burned and still the lion laughed and laughed and laughed! He scowled. Just what was so funny? What even was *Bark*? And *After Dark*? What was that? His stomach churned sickeningly.

“I’m sorry.” Timon wiped tears from his eyes. “Maybe you’re too innocent for that. You’re so sweet, you are, Liam.”

The otter flinched. Was that supposed to be a compliment? The lion covered the otter’s paw with his own, fingers curling around the smaller, neater paw. Trying to pull away as his heart beat accelerated at an alarming rate, Liam found it tucked quite firmly in an iron grip.

“Uh...” He mumbled, words failing him. “Just what are you doing?”

“Holding your paw. Is that so strange?”

The lion blinked, a flash of doubt overshadowing his face for the briefest of moments. His fingertips tightened in.

“I know I’m forward. I do hope I haven’t overstepped. A guy’s just got to take a chance where he sees it...right? There’s no sense in not trying when you have will to try.”

“Take a chance on what?”

Playing dumb – well, the lion already thought he was innocent – Liam managed to wrestle his paw away and flexed his fingers. What was he supposed to do in such a situation? He didn’t want his paw grabbed! Nevertheless, he felt a stirring of guilt as Timon’s face fell, eyes downcast as he slowly withdrew his paw, so slowly that Liam wondered if Timon was hoping he’d stop him. Yet Liam held fast, ignoring his stomach doing back flips. It would only be worse if he went along with it. That’d get him *nowhere*.

“Are you with Darren then?” Timon asked, lips twisting. “It’s okay if you’re not really ‘out’ yet. You can tell me.”

The otter barely managed to not roll his eyes. He didn’t give a toss about being out as gay or not! Though many did care. His brow furrowed. And if he wasn’t out and cared about that shit, he wouldn’t fucking tell a random lion all about it either! He scowled, rubbing his muzzle. What planet was the lion living on?

“What’s wrong?” A smile played across Timon’s muzzle, the lion not taking things as seriously as the otter felt he should. “Are you really with Darren after all that fuss? You would make a cute couple, I’ll give you that.”

His tone flared sour on the last utterance and Liam coughed into his paw. His stomach rolled as if he was on a boat. How could he ever finish his wine? Even in the quiet bar everything was too close and claustrophobic, closing in from all sides. The otter swallowed hard, steadying himself the best he could. He couldn’t let it control him. What was there to be anxious about?

“Timon,” he said with difficulty. “Is this suppose to be a date?”

“You didn’t answer my question but, well...”

He licked his lips and gave an awkward smile.

“I hoped you wouldn’t mind. It is all right, isn’t it? For us to be on a date? Together?”

“It would have been nice to be asked properly.”

The lion started, Liam’s blunt reply catching him on the back foot. Almost comical, he looked from left to right as if seeking help, yet not a soul from his usual audience could be found to assist.

“Uh... That’s a bit sharp?” Timon bristled. “I’ve taken you out for wine and you’re being ever so rude to me. Why is that?”

The otter took a deep breath. He struggled to keep from tightening his paw into a fist, fingertips tapping restlessly. Outside the window across the bar, night crept upon them, drawing the duo into twilight dispute. Liam concentrated on breathing evenly. Why was he nude? Why had he said that? But hadn’t the lion been rude too? His head spun.

“Why didn’t you tell me it was a date then?” He countered. “Instead of hiding it under the guise of us hanging out as friends? You can’t say that that isn’t weird.”

Timon frowned and brushed a paw back through his mane. If his intent had been to smooth down the ruffled fur, he failed dismally, as he only managed to make even more of a mess of the rats nest. Growling, he scrambled out of the booth to the bar, despite the fact that his glass was till half-full. OR more like three-quarters full. He hadn’t had very much of it.

Struck by sudden, childish rebellion, Liam snagged Timon's glass, drawing it to him with a scrape of glass on wood. He sipped from it delicately, liquid confidence swishing around his mouth.

Hm. Not bad.

Timon returned with a calmer, softer smile brightening his muzzle, two fresh glasses of ruby red wine in paw. He set them down with care and pushed Liam's closer to his paw, which rested on the table top.

"Here... I'm sorry about that. That was uncalled for." The tips of his rounded ears were flushed. "I just don't see why it's a problem...but I could have been clearer and maybe should have been clearer. I'm sorry."

Timon held Liam's gaze.

"I thought you'd say no, if I asked. If I was clear. I was afraid you'd say no."

Liam's mouth opened but no sound came out. He grasped his white wine with a shaking paw, spilled a few drops, and went for the red in lieu. Keeping his paw as steady as possible, he sampled the new wine, buying himself time. It rang oaken on his tongue, a more pleasurable, distracting flavour.

"Thanks for the wine, you didn't have to. Why would you be afraid though? You come off so..." He waved a paw. "Self-assured. Confident. You don't seem to be one to worry"

Before Timon could answer, a waiter appeared with a platter of bread, cheese and olives, neatly punctuating the end of Liam's sentence. Smiling as politely and non-awkwardly as they were able, the lion and the otter thanked the waiter, who folded his paws over his white apron, black vest jacket pristine. His shirt sleeves were rolled up to the elbows and the slender mouse's whiskers quivered as he described, without hesitation, every cheese and olive on the board and exactly how they would complement their choice of wine.

"I wouldn't be sure how to answer that," Timon said once the waiter had made good his exit. "Aren't we all a little afraid sometimes? Sometimes more than others? No one likes to be rejected."

Sliding his paw very deliberately across the table, Timon brushed Liam's smallest finger with his index, a genuine if uncertain warmth in his eyes. Nipping the inside of his cheek, Liam held still, steeling himself to not pull away. He had to be still. He had to do it – it was only a touch, nothing sinister. It was every bit as difficult as expected. His fingers shook as he, against all odds, allowed Timon to touch him, if not completely hold his paw in a lover's handshake. Maybe one day he would be comfortable with that.

Liam allowed himself to imagine. What could that kind of life be like, if he could do it? Cinema date. Holding paws. Sunsets. Beaches. City nights. Soft kisses. The lion, bare but his fur, moving over him on the bed. Nuzzling down to his...

The otter blushed. His daydream was cheesy but didn't everyone want a little bit of the cheesy too sometimes? If they could be scared sometimes, they could have the cheesier side

of life too – and not on a platter. Maybe he could have that too. Just maybe. Maybe he only had to try. He swallowed and took a piece of orange cheese. Nibbling along the edge, he widened his eyes at the rich tang of flavour exploding on his tongue to fill his mouth.

“You’re right,” he said at last. “No one likes to be rejected at all. It’s far from a good feeling.”

Timon shook his head, spearing an olive with a tiny fork. The otter chanced he saw a secretive smile on his muzzle but put it down to his over active imagination. He couldn’t read too much into things. It was only a smile, if that at all.

“Does that mean that this is a date then?” Timon winked slyly, looking up through his mane, which curled out above his eyes. “And would you like to go with me on another one?”

Liam wondered, did he? What did he want? A relationship wasn’t at the front of his mind or high on his list of priorities. Or was it? Did he want that romance that had been denied to him so far? A few dates in his past hardly counted as any kind of relationship – school and college flings, as they were. There was nothing to them. And now there was a lion sitting right across from him, tail swishing hopefully. Liam closed his eyes.

Where was the harm?

“I think I can manage that.”